



MENTAL STRENGTH

Positivity and Optimism

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13%

of participants experience
challenges with Positivity

100%

Positivity is a strength for 100% of
people with **high levels** of
resilience

84%

Positivity is a strength for 84% of
people with **average levels** of
resilience

6%

Positivity is a strength for 6% of
people with **low levels** of
resilience

Other Strengths commonly associated with Positivity:

Purpose, Goals, Self-Awareness, Self-Esteem, Inviting Feedback, Awareness of Strengths & Weaknesses



Positivity and Optimism



Are you a glass half full or a glass half empty person?



The average person has c. 12,000 to 60,000 thoughts per day.* Of these, 80% are negative and 95% are the same thoughts as the day before.

*2005, National Science Foundation



85% of what we worry about never happens.

2005, Leahy, Cornell University



When a worry does become reality, 79% of people find that they can handle the difficulty better than expected or that the difficulty taught them a lesson worth learning.



Leahy concluded that 97% of our worries are baseless and result from an unfounded pessimistic perception.



Baseless worries are a major source of stress, tension and cause of exhaustion not only for the mind, but also for the physical body

The Negativity Bias: Positivity v Negativity



Think of a positive experience that recently happened to you such as being praised by your manager for your performance on a task and answer the following questions:

QUESTION	OPTIMIST	PESSIMIST
Why did it happen?	Because of my abilities	Due to external factors
What does it suggest?	Other positive things can happen	This was a one-off stroke of luck
This incident proves	More success is possible	This happened by chance and won't be repeated



Think of a negative experience that recently happened to you such as difficulties collaborating with another team member and answer the following questions:

QUESTION	OPTIMIST	PESSIMIST
Why did it happen?	External factors	My inability
What does it suggest?	This is an isolated incident	More negative things will happen
This incident proves	This is a temporary setback	More bad things will happen

How did you do?

- We react more strongly to negative events than positive events even when they are equal.
- We have more vivid memories of negative events than positive ones and think about them more frequently, which increases the likelihood of them shaping our future decision making.
- One negative incident can outweigh our overall impression of a generally positive situation.

The Negativity Bias: The Impact

Examples of Negativity Bias:



PERFORMANCE REVIEW

Despite a good overall outcome noting your achievements and strong performance, you focus disproportionately on the constructive feedback highlighting some areas for development.



PRESENTATION

You still vividly recall a customer presentation you gave a year ago in which you displayed the wrong data, despite giving a good presentation overall. In reality the customer has probably forgotten about it.



- Humans are more sensitive to negative events and stimuli, dwell on them more and remember them more vividly, often overriding any generally positive experiences.
- We place more weight on negative aspects when making decisions and when forming impressions of others.
- Once a survival advantage, this negativity bias can be detrimental, leading to low self-confidence, self-esteem and motivation, increased anxiety, self-doubt, fear, stress, pessimism, depression, relationship problems.
- In career terms, it can cause us to limit our potential by refusing promotion, being unwilling to take on challenges, a new job, learn a new skill, achieve a goal.
- However, our brains are capable of constantly reshaping and rewiring themselves (neuroplasticity), and with effort and practice, you can create new, more positive neural pathways.

Sources of Negative Thoughts



PAST REGRETS

'If only I had done that before...'

'I should have listened to the advice I was given.'

Regretting how you acted in the past and believing that you should have done something different leads to frustration, more negativity and potentially depression.



- Don't live in the past, learn from it.



FEAR OF THE FUTURE

"What if I don't succeed?"

"What if I am made redundant?"

By asking these sorts of questions we send our thoughts into a negative spiral.



- Remain in the present.



COMPARING WITH OTHERS

In a world of social media, it's easier than ever to compare ourselves to someone else who we may feel inferior to.



- Focus on yourself, not others.



BLAME

'I haven't been to the gym because you don't want to go anymore'

'I failed my exam because the right questions didn't come up'



- Take control and responsibility for your own choices.



CATASTROPHISING

'If I don't make this sale I could lose my job.'

'No one will respect me if I make a mess of this presentation.'

You automatically assume the worst will happen without facts to support it.



- Challenge anxious thoughts.

Benefits of Positive Thinking



INCREASED LIFE SPAN

Optimists live 10-15% longer on average, plus have a greater chance of longevity – over 85 years.

Nurses Health Study 2004-2014, women. Veterans Affairs Normative Aging study, 1986-2016, men.



HAPPY HEART

Optimism is associated with a lower risk of cardiovascular events and all-cause mortality.

2019, Alan Rozanski study of 200,000 cases.



IMPROVED HEALTH

Optimism positively impacts mental and physical health.

2010, Alessandro Rotundo.



INCREASED SELF-EFFICACY

Optimism is closely linked to higher levels of self-efficacy.



INCREASED RESILIENCE

Optimists bounce back more quickly from setbacks and rejection than pessimists.

Benefits of Positive Thinking in the Workplace



Encourages you to step outside your comfort zone

We are more confident and willing to take on new tasks, set goals, take risks, seize opportunities such as promotion, training or a new job.



Encourages a growth mindset and increased skill acquisition

We actively enhance our skill set through formal training and learning from colleagues. Challenges become opportunities for growth rather than threats.



Improves professional relationships and networking

People are attracted to positive thinkers resulting in improved interaction and communication, better relationships, networking and career progression.



Improves conflict management

Positivity gives us the confidence to keep any conflict in perspective, to consider other's opinions and to accept that there are other viewpoints and solutions.



Improves cognitive function

and emotional regulation due to a reduction in stress hormones. Our mood and often that of those around us is improved.



Improves self-awareness

We are more open to feedback seeing it as an opportunity to develop and improve by identifying our strengths and weaknesses.



Productivity is increased

We feel good about our future, are more motivated, alert, energetic, focused and productive.



Reduces Stress

We no longer dwell on problems, challenges are viewed as minor setbacks, stress triggers are reduced.

Best Practice for Positivity and Optimism – Be a Role Model



Express Gratitude- record 3 positive things from your day- achievements, people, events.



Communicate positively using positive words and body language.



Employ active listening and notice non-verbal cues.



Show appreciation to others- a simple thank you.



Set realistic goals.



Surround yourself with positive influences and people, embrace different perspectives.



Challenge negative self-talk, look forward not back, apply what you have learnt from a situation.



Re-direct your attention when re-living negative thoughts- listen to music, read, walk, and use positive affirmations (“I can do this”).



Reframe situations in a more positive light, rather than focusing on any bad aspects.



Take time to savour and bank successes however small, focusing on how they made you feel.



Cultivate a growth mindset- see challenges as opportunities for growth, problems as minor setbacks.



Participate in activities that reduce stress and boost mood: yoga, physical challenges, volunteering, socialising, and practice self-care.

Reframing Negative Thoughts

Exercise 1 Addressing Negative Thoughts

Think of a situation that triggers negative thoughts.
Then, challenge those thoughts by arguing with yourself:

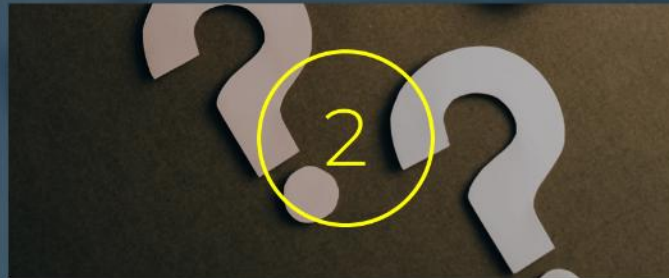


The first step is to realise
you have a choice about
how you feel



RECORD

Write down what you are
saying to yourself:
E.g. 'I am not good enough.'
'I won't get that promotion.'



QUESTION

Ask yourself; 'What evidence is
there to support this?' or, 'what
is another way of looking at
this?' Argue with yourself that
you are wrong.



ADJUST

Adjust your thoughts so that
they better reflect the reality
of the situation, as opposed to
your perception of it.

Reframing Negative Thoughts

Exercise 2 Asking The Question, 'What if?'

Think of an example where you are worrying about a future event and only seeing the negative possibilities.



Write down the issue, and then write down 5 'what if' statements with good potential outcomes.

EXAMPLE: For an organisation restructure where you may be worried about losing your job:

What if I get a new opportunity?

What if I get to learn new skills?



Whilst these new thoughts may not change the outcome, it will make you more energised and hopeful and may provide a new direction that you hadn't considered before.

Reframing Negative Thoughts

Exercise 3 Reframing Thoughts

NEGATIVE THOUGHT	REFRAMED POSITIVE THOUGHT
I have never done it before	It's a great opportunity to learn something new
It's too complex	I'll come at it from a different angle
I don't have the resources	What would it take to make it happen?
My workload is too great	What can we prioritise?
I am the victim of the past	I can take control of my destiny
We've always done it this way	There may be a better way of doing things
They have got it wrong	Let me understand their point of view and offer some alternative ideas
The problem is.....	Here are some ideas to fix things
Why did they get the promotion, it's unfair	What can I do to make sure I am promoted next time round
Too much to do, I don't know where to start	Let's break the problem down and make a start
I am tired of all these changes	Let's explore what opportunities may come from these changes

Reframing Negative Thoughts

Exercise 4 Martin Seligman ABCDE Model

Think of a recent situation in which you had negative feelings and write down your thoughts in the order outlined in the ABCDE model;

A

ADVERSITY

What is the situation.
Stick to the facts, what actually happened?

B

BELIEFS

Write down the thoughts you had during and after the situation.

C

CONSEQUENCES

Look at the impact of these thoughts – How did you feel? What happened then?

D

DISPUTATION

Actively dispute your beliefs that sent you into the downward spiral. (Think about it as if you are giving advice to your best friend who called you asking for help.)

Generate alternatives to these beliefs.

Practice arguing with yourself/Imaginary friend in a productive way.

E

ENERGISATION (ACTION)

Notice what happens to your energy levels as you dispel these negative beliefs.

Acknowledge the situation, thoughts, and feelings.

Challenge the thoughts - not the feelings.

Reframing Negative Thoughts

Exercise 5 Individual or Group Exercise

This exercise helps participants understand the emotional impact of positive and negative thoughts by physically moving between two chairs representing each perspective. As they respond to situational questions, they switch positions to experience and evaluate how each thinking pattern affects their feelings, and at the end assess which one they prefer. Carry out this exercise using the situational questions below to compose your own positive or negative thoughts OR use the examples given. See how positive v negative thinking makes you feel.

1 Example ONE of situational question: your organisation announces that it will be undertaking restructuring, what is your reaction?

POSITIVE THOUGHTS	NEGATIVE THOUGHTS
Unnecessary processes and operations may be eliminated.	Redundancies
Objectives may shift from process-driven objectives to achieving business goals.	Uncertainty during the restructuring causing high levels of stress and potential conflict with colleagues.
Increased efficiency, morale and productivity.	Fear of having to learn new technology and processes.
Long-term stability and growth.	Increased workload especially if there are workforce reductions.
New challenges that enable professional learning and development.	Impact on customers including potential loss of clients/contracts.
Opportunities for promotion &/or pay rises.	There may be a better way of doing things.

2 Example TWO of situational question: Another team member working on a project with you disagrees strongly with the approach you suggest, what is your reaction?

POSITIVE THOUGHTS	NEGATIVE THOUGHTS
It's good that your colleague has their own opinions and is proposing some alternative solutions.	They don't like me.
Since both of you are engaging in the process, the ultimate responsibility will be shared between the two of you.	They think I'm no good at my job.
Being able to explore a number of different options will result in a better overall solution for your organisation and the client.	They will tell my manager that I'm not up to the task.
Collaborating in this way builds a good working relationship with your colleague which will be useful for future projects.	The customer will lose confidence in me and ask for the other person in future.